

ATI Radeon X850

Graphic Details!

The Radeon X850XT Platinum Edition 256 MB card is ATI's top-of-the-line card. Based around the R480 GPU, it uses 130nm manufacturing process to obtain higher clock speeds. This is probably the first ATI card to employ a two-slot cooling system. The leaf blower fans, first seen on the nVidia cards, do a good job on the Radeon as well.

We tested the card on the Intel D925XCV motherboard with 1 GB of DDR II 533 MHz memory, 250 GB Maxtor and Windows XP and the latest updates and patches. We used the latest 4.12 catalyst drivers.

The card, as expected, performed superbly posting some of the best scores we have ever seen. In 3D Mark05, the X850XT PE logged an amazing 5540, the best ever by any card. Below a resolution of 1600x1200, the card becomes CPU-bound and a lot depends on your CPU speed.

X850XT PE Specifications	
Core clock	540
Pixel fill-rate	8.6G pixels/sec
Texture fill-rate	8.6G textures/sec
Memory Speed	590MHz GDDR3
Onboard Memory	256MB

Scores At 1600 x 1200	
Call Of Duty	202
Doom 3	47
Half-Life 2	48.35
Far Cry	57.9
Halo	55.49
3DMark 2005	5540

To avoid this, we ran our benchmarks at a resolution of 1600x1200.

We ran Doom3, Half-Life 2, Far Cry and Halo benchmarks and the card came through with flying colours on all counts. One point to note here is that Doom3 prefers nVidia cards and hence, cards based on 6800 Ultra do better than ATI ones, however, the reverse is true for ATI when it comes to Half-Life 2. Which brings us to the million dollar question: Which card should you buy? That would depend on which game engine developers prefer—Doom3 or Half-Life 2.

Enough of benchmarking, we also put the card to a real world test and played all these and many more games with pumped up effects. The games play was smooth, effects awesome and not once did the fan blower raise its decibel to exert grievances! But as with all high-end cards, availability may be an issue.

Company **ATI**
Price **NA**
Phone **NA**
E-mail **NA**
Web site **www.ati.com**

Rating 



ScanSoft PDF Converter Pro 2

Convert Anything!

This software converts web pages, Word documents, Excel sheets and PowerPoint files into PDF and PDF files back into Word documents. It allows you to convert files in multiple formats at the same time into a PDF file each or merge them as a single PDF file.

The software has a fairly simple interface and a comprehensive list of options. You do need Microsoft PowerPoint, Word and Excel installed on your machine, though, or else, an 'unrecognised file format' error follows. You can choose to convert all or selected pages, size your own page, resolution, scale, colour scheme and more.

When converting to PDF, there is no feature that lets you allow the software to choose the appropriate size so that all the content fits into the PDF page. You must set the size by trial and error as with an incorrect page size the format and layout of the pages goes awry.

PDF to Word was smooth with minimal misalignment which was easily correctable.

The software didn't work too well with Excel and PowerPoint, although it did perform admirably in the Word-PDF and vice-versa conversions.

Company **ScanSoft International**
Price **Rs 5,995**
Phone **011-26207477**
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Rating 



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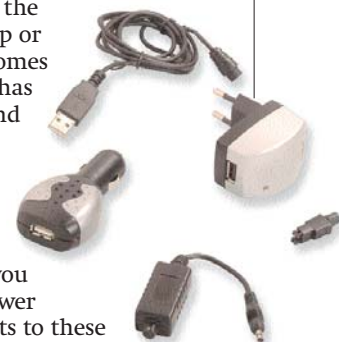
Travel PAC 3-in-1 USB Mobile Charger

This neat little gadget from Travel PAC promises to put to rest all the low battery jitters with your mobile phone. You can charge Nokia and Sony Ericsson phones using the device straight from the USB port on your desktop or notebook computer. It comes with a USB cable which has an adapter at one end and a Nokia/Sony Ericsson plug at the other. A thoughtful addition is a cigarette lighter adapter for charging in your car and an AC plug in case you want to use standard power sockets. The USB connects to these devices to draw power as well.

In our tests, we could even charge the Nokia 2280, a device not on the compatibility sheet. If only it was compatible with other cell phones, what with Samsung and LG making their presence felt in the market. It is slightly expensive at Rs 905, but the convenience is worth it. A very useful tool for all the frequent travellers!

Company **Camac Holdings**
Price **Rs 905**
Phone **033-22207961**
E-mail **camac11@vsnl.net**
Web site **http://www.pac.com.sg**

Rating 



1 Poor: Has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application. **2 Mediocre:** Does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas. **3 Average:** Reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product. **4 Good:** A good buy, better than most products in its category. **5 Excellent:** A brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations.